

Tourism: Envisioning a Transformation

To tap into the growing demand for domestic travel, India must focus on building new destinations, enhance capacity at key tourist spots, and continue infrastructural development

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OVER THE PAST DECADE or so, India has significantly enhanced its stature in the world as a destination of business opportunities. This has also helped India to claim an increasingly prominent place on the global travel and tourism map as an important globetrotting destination. The domestic travel and tourism industry has also evolved and grown on the back of material infrastructure improvement, growing earnings of the Indian middle- and upper-middle classes, and thanks to the growing desire to spend more on travel.

The industry has recorded growth across all segments and price points, and travel has moved recently from the discretionary spends column to becoming a part of every household's budget plan post pandemic. What makes the upcoming decade exciting is the fact that there is a growing interest among Indian travellers to explore the vast expanse of our own country. In order to tap into this growing demand, we need to focus on building new destinations within the country, enhance capacity of the key tourist spots with sustainability embedded in them and continue the acceler-



BY RAJESH MAGOW

DIRECT FLIGHTS, NEW TRAIN ROUTES, AND DESTINATION-LEVEL REJUVENATION HAVE SIMPLIFIED TRAVEL AND TOURISM

ated pace of infrastructural development in the country for efficient connectivity and a hassle-free destination experience.

With the call to explore our own backyard being as resonant as it is right now, we as a nation would be remiss not to make this the cornerstone of our initiatives over the next few years. Connectivity and better experiences emerge as the linchpin in transforming the travel and tourism landscapes. Drawing inspiration from the success stories scattered across India, we find notable examples of how direct flights, new train routes or even a destination-level rejuvenation have resulted in making travel and tourism easier for people. Since its inauguration in November 2020, the Darbhanga airport has emerged as one of the top UDAN airports. It remained in the Top 50 ranks in 2022 and 2023. The new airport at Itanagar played a critical role in opening up the Northeast to pan-India travellers.

On the railways front, we witnessed the highest growth from the recently launched Vande Bharat sectors (Chandigarh-Delhi, Chennai-Bengaluru, Mumbai-Pune, etc.), which bears testimony to people enjoying and willing to spend more for a better experience. By strategically ramping up connectivity, building and promoting